

which to write lofty articles for Delhi papers evoking the grand old days of struggle. Instead it meant continuing the fight for the poor, the dispossessed, the caste-victims, women and others society had spurned or trod upon. No surprise, then, that 12 of those 20 prison terms were in free India.

One of the best read (and travelled) politicians of any time, "Dr" Lohia (the degree was real, a Ph.D in economics from Berlin, awarded when he was 23 for a thesis written in German—he refused to consider studying in Britain) could hold forth with equal fervour (or virulence, to his detractors) on caste, race, religion, politics, economics, constitution, law, music, art, literature. He kept open house at his home on Rakabganj Road in Delhi and anyone could walk in and strike up a conversation. My dad was an infrequent caller, but would come back each time enchanted by Lohia's brilliant formulations. He could speak Hindi, Urdu, Bengali, French, German and—despite all his opposition to the language as the whip-hand that held the Indian people down—delectable English. To read his writings is to marvel at the sweep of his intellect. Quite properly, one of his books is called *Fragments of a World Mind*.

Every piece of information was fodder for his theses: the originality of his analysis of the Olympics medal tally could put Hercule Poirot's deductions in *Cards on the Table* to shame. He wrote to the minister of jails, Uttar Pradesh (a former freedom movement colleague), from his jail cell in 1957, "...In our country animals are butchered mercilessly. I was shocked to hear that portions of live tortoises are sold in the Calcutta market. Limb after limb is severed and sold, and the poor creature is all the time writhing in agony...the current Indian mind has become wantonly cruel. If animals are the recipients of such beastly torture, men like me cannot escape at least a part of it."

What would Lohia have thought of today's India? Well, here's what he wrote: "Inequality between little and



Q: What was the subject of his Ph.D thesis at the Berlin University?

A: Socio-economic theory of Salt Satyagraha, focusing on Gandhi's

Q: Which political party did he form?

A: Congress Socialist Party

Q: Who was his long-time friend and comrade during and after the freedom struggle?

A: Jayaprakash Narayan

Q: What was his first contribution to the freedom struggle?

A: Organising a protest on the death of Lokmanya Tilak

Q: Which Delhi hospital was named after him?

A: Willingdon Hospital

big men is there in all the world, but in India this difference is killing. In white countries, whether communist or capitalist, differences in income are two, five or seven times. In India this difference is generally fifty hundred or three hundred times. As a result, there is no food or clothing on one hand and there is always increasing play of modernism and luxury on the other." It was Lohia who raised the 3-anna/15-anna controversy in his maiden speech in Parliament, and wrote the pamphlet *25,000 Rupees a Day*, a commentary on the prime minister's security budget, in a poor country. Like Gandhi, Lohia had a sense of outrage and shame. It was Gandhi who wrote: "The poor sisters of Orissa have no saris; they are in rags. Yet they have not lost all sense of decency; but, I assure you, we have. We are naked in spite of our clothing and they are clothed in spite of their nakedness."

If Lohia was alive today, one can only guess what he would have said, but I'm pretty sure I know where he would (want to) be—in jail.

The author, whose father was Lohia's colleague in the Congress Socialist Party, is working on a website, drlohia.com to mark Lohia's birth centenary